

CLEAR THE CLUTTER · ROOM BY ROOM

The 12-Week Decluttering Workbook

15 Minutes a Day, One Room a Week: Keep, Donate, Sell or Toss Your Way
Through the Whole House, No Storage Bins Required

Emily P. Harper

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by Emily P. Harper

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First edition, 2026. This workbook is undated and can be started in any week of any year.

Interior set in Atkinson Hyperlegible and Barlow.

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Fifteen Minutes, One Room at a Time

If you picked up this book, there is probably a closet or a whole room you have been avoiding for a while. Maybe you have tried a weekend blitz before, pulled everything out onto the bed, and ended up at midnight shoving half of it back in because you ran out of energy before you ran out of stuff. That experience is common enough that this book is built around the opposite approach: small amounts of time, spread over twelve weeks, one room after another.

Here is the whole promise. For 12 weeks, you spend 15 minutes a day making decisions about the things in your home, and by the end you will have gone through every room at least once. You will also know what left the house, how much money came back from what you sold, and what you gave away, with the value written down in case you want it for your records. That is all this book asks of you, and it is all it claims to deliver.

What it will not do is teach you to organize. There are no labeling systems here and no drawer dividers, and I will never tell you to go buy a set of matching bins. The bags and boxes you already have in the house are enough, and Week 0 lists exactly what to gather before you start.

INTRODUCTION

Why deciding comes first

Most clutter advice starts in the wrong place, in my opinion. It shows you a beautiful shelf of clear containers and suggests that the problem is a storage problem. For most homes it is a decision problem, because every item you have not decided about is still taking up space, whether it sits in a pile on the counter or in a pretty basket on a shelf. Organizing things you do not want just gives you tidier clutter.

So the work in these pages is almost entirely deciding. You pick up an object, you decide what happens to it, and you put it in the right place for that decision. Once most of the extra is gone, organizing what is left tends to take care of itself, because there is simply less to arrange. If you still want bins at the end of Week 12, buy them then, when you know exactly what is going inside.

INTRODUCTION

The four boxes

Every item you touch goes into one of four boxes: **Keep**, **Donate**, **Sell** or **Toss**. They can be cardboard boxes or heavy-duty trash bags with a strip of tape on each one. What matters is that there are four, and that they are there before you open the first drawer.

- **Keep** means it goes back into the room, in a place where you can find it. Keep does not mean “set it aside for later.”

- **Donate** is for things in good enough shape that someone else would use them.
- **Sell** is for things worth the time it takes to list them and meet a buyer.
- **Toss** is for anything broken, expired, stained or missing its parts. Recycle what you can.

At the end of each week there is a page called “Keep / Donate / Sell / Toss Count,” where you tally what went where. It looks like bookkeeping, and it is, but after a few weeks those numbers show you plainly that the house is changing.

When you can't decide

You will hit items that do not fit neatly anywhere. A sweater you like but never wear, or the charger for a phone you gave up years ago. For those, use one question as the tie-breaker:

If this were gone tomorrow, would I go out and buy it again?

If the honest answer is yes, it is a Keep. If the answer is no, or “I’d have to think about it,” it leaves the house. From there, the only question is whether it goes to Donate or Sell, and that depends on money and patience. A good rule is to pick a dollar amount below which selling is not worth your time. For some people that is \$20, for others it is \$50 or more. Write your number down in Week 0 and stick to it, so you are not debating every single item.

You will notice there is no “maybe” box. I left it out on purpose, since a maybe box is usually just the old clutter moved into a new container. If you truly cannot answer the question today, it is a Keep for now, and you will meet it again when you do a 15-minute reset later in the book.

INTRODUCTION

Why the rooms go in this order

The weeks do not follow the layout of a house. They follow difficulty, starting with the rooms where decisions are quick and moving toward the ones where they are slow and sometimes painful.

Week 1 is the bathroom, because almost everything in there has an expiration date or a clear use, and most people can fill a Toss bag in a single session without feeling guilty about any of it. That first quick result is the whole reason it comes first. After that you move through the entryway, the kitchen (split over two weeks, since it holds more than most people expect), the living room and your bedroom. The closet has its own week because clothes are usually the biggest pile and the easiest to sell. Then come the kids’ rooms or a hobby room, the paper pile, the linen and laundry closets, and finally the garage, basement and attic, where the volume is large and the jobs have to be broken into 15-minute pieces.

Sentimental things wait until Week 12. By then you will have made a few hundred small decisions, and you will know how your own hesitation feels and what usually settles it. You will also have more room in the house, which makes it easier to keep the few things that truly matter where you can see them. Letters, photos, a parent’s watch and your kids’ drawings deserve that kind of attention, and they get a full week with pages to photograph an item and write down its story before you decide what to do with the object itself. Some people find that week easy after everything else, while others still find it hard, and that is fine too.

How to use the pages

Each week opens with a short page about the room, followed by “This Week, 15 Minutes a Day,” which gives you seven small tasks, one per day, with a box to check. After that come the pages specific to that room, and the week closes with your count and a space for notes and wins. You can skip a day. You can also take two weeks for a room if your kitchen is bigger than the plan assumes, since nobody is grading you on the calendar.

The section called Where It All Went is where you keep track of everything that went out of the house, with a Sell Tracker and a Donation Log. The section called Keep It Clear helps you keep the house from filling up again, and when the decluttering is done, the *House Cleaning Checklist Planner* picks up the routine for keeping it clean.

Before you start, turn to the Printable Declutter Kit page at the back of this book. It tells you how to get the kit, which is handy if you would rather print fresh sheets than write in the book, or if more than one person in the house wants to follow along.

Then go to Week 0, walk through your home with a pencil, and don’t touch anything yet.



Walk Through Your Home Before You Touch Anything

Before you open a single drawer, take one slow walk through your home with this book and a pencil. Go room by room and don't pick anything up. You are looking at each space the way a visitor would, and giving it an honest number from 1 to 5. This book follows a typical home layout. Yours may differ, with more bedrooms, no garage or a shared space, so use the closest week for each space and adapt the pages to fit your home.

Those numbers matter more than they seem to right now. In Week 12 you will rate the same rooms again, and the gap between the two sets of scores is your proof that 12 weeks of 15-minute blocks did something, which is easy to forget in the middle of a messy Tuesday. Take a photo of each room from the doorway too. Nobody has to see them but you.

After the walk, make three practical choices: the day you start, the 15 minutes you will protect each day, and the dollar amount below which an item goes to Donate instead of Sell. Pick a time that already exists in your day, such as right after the morning coffee or while dinner is in the oven. A slot that depends on having a free moment rarely survives the first busy week.

Last, gather what you need from around the house. Nothing on the list costs money, and if you don't have something, skip it and use what you do have.

Week 0 has no daily tasks. Four things to finish, in one or two sittings:

1. Rate all 12 rooms and take the before photos.
2. Write down your start date and your 15-minute slot.
3. Set your sell threshold.
4. Gather the bags, boxes and labels.

Rate Your Rooms

Walk through each space and circle one number. Use 2 or 4 if the room falls between two descriptions. Trust your first reaction. Check the box once you have taken the before photo from the doorway, and remember where you stood so you can take the after photo from the same spot in Week 12.

- ① **Calm.** Easy to use, and everything has a place.
- ③ **Crowded.** You can use it, but it takes effort to find or put away things.
- ⑤ **Stuck.** You avoid the room, or it can't be used the way it was meant to be.

WEEK	ROOM	RATING (1 TO 5)	BEFORE PHOTO
Week 1	Bathroom	① ② ③ ④ ⑤	☐
Week 2	Entryway and coat closet	① ② ③ ④ ⑤	☐
Week 3	Kitchen, part one: counters, pantry, fridge	① ② ③ ④ ⑤	☐
Week 4	Kitchen, part two: cabinets, gadgets, containers	① ② ③ ④ ⑤	☐
Week 5	Living room	① ② ③ ④ ⑤	☐
Week 6	Bedroom	① ② ③ ④ ⑤	☐
Week 7	Closet	① ② ③ ④ ⑤	☐
Week 8	Kids' rooms and toys (or hobby room)	① ② ③ ④ ⑤	☐
Week 9	Home office and paper pile	① ② ③ ④ ⑤	☐
Week 10	Linen closet, laundry, cleaning supplies	① ② ③ ④ ⑤	☐
Week 11	Garage, basement, attic, storage	① ② ③ ④ ⑤	☐
Week 12	Sentimental things	① ② ③ ④ ⑤	☐

Add up your 12 ratings: _____ / 60

Pick Your Start Date and Your 15 Minutes

Tie the 15 minutes to something you already do, like the morning coffee, school drop-off or dinner cleanup.

Start date: _____ / _____ / _____

My daily 15-minute slot: _____

I will do it right after: _____

Backup time if that falls through: _____

Who will help or cheer me on: _____

My sell threshold: \$ _____

Items worth less than this go to Donate, not Sell. Items worth this much or more are worth the time it takes to list them and meet a buyer. Some people pick \$20, others \$50 or more. You can change it later, but set it now so you aren't debating every object.

When You Can't Decide

Go through these steps, in order, for every item you pick up. There is no "maybe" box.

1	Is it broken, expired, stained or missing its parts?	Toss it. Recycle what you can.
2	If this were gone tomorrow, would I go out and buy it again?	Yes: Keep. It goes back in the room, in a place where you can find it.
3	If the answer is no, or "I'd have to think about it": is it worth my sell threshold or more?	Yes: Sell. No: Donate.

What to Have on Hand

Collect these before Week 1. Everything here is something most homes already have. Don't buy anything new for this book.

- ☐ Four boxes or heavy-duty trash bags, one each for Keep, Donate, Sell and Toss
- ☐ Tape and a marker to label each one
- ☐ A pencil or pen that lives with this book
- ☐ A timer (the one on your phone works) set to 15 minutes
- ☐ Extra trash bags and a recycling bin nearby
- ☐ A rag or paper towels for wiping shelves as you empty them
- ☐ A phone or camera for before photos
- ☐ A few sticky notes for things you need to look up, like what something might sell for

Where the Boxes Will Live

Pick spots now so you aren't deciding while you're holding a stack of towels.

The Keep box waits here between sessions: _____

The Donate box lives by (the door, the car, the garage): _____

Sell items wait here until I list them: _____

The day I take the Donate box out of the house: _____

First Walk-Through Notes

The room I'm dreading most: _____

The room I expect to be easiest: _____

What I want from these 12 weeks: _____

NOTES + WINS

Week 0 Is Done When

- ☐ All 12 rooms are rated and I added up the total
- ☐ The before photos are taken
- ☐ My start date and 15-minute slot are written down
- ☐ My sell threshold is set
- ☐ My supplies are gathered and the boxes have a home



The Bathroom: A Fast First Win

The bathroom is small, it has a door that closes, and almost nothing in it comes with a memory. That makes it a good place to start. Most of what you pick up will have an easy answer: the mascara from two summers ago, the hotel samples, the third bottle of the same shampoo, the cold medicine that expired before the cold did.

You will work one drawer or cabinet a day, so the whole room is done in a week and you never face all of it at once. Empty one space onto the counter, wipe it down and sort every item into the four boxes: Keep, Donate, Sell, Toss. Then put the Keep items back where you can reach them. Most bathroom things end up in Toss. A few, like unopened toiletries and towels in good shape, can go to Donate. Very little here is worth selling, so don't spend your 15 minutes on listings.

Expired medicines and old products need a couple of extra steps. The next pages walk you through them. When the timer rings, stop, even if you are halfway through a shelf, and pick it up again tomorrow. On the last page, write down your counts, however small. That is your first win.

WEEK 1 · THE BATHROOM: A FAST FIRST WIN

This Week, 15 Minutes a Day

1

Counter and sink. Clear everything off. Wipe the surface. Put back only what you used today.

15 MIN

☐

2

Medicine cabinet or shelf. Check the expiration date on every item and set aside what has expired or what you no longer need.

15 MIN

☐

3

Under the sink. Empty it, wipe it and sort.

15 MIN

☐

4

Makeup, skin care and sunscreen. Sort with the date rules on page 4 of this week.

15 MIN

☐

5

Hair and tools. Brushes, styling tools, hair products and the junk drawer of hair ties.

15 MIN

☐

6

Shower, tub and towels. Bottles, bath mats, towels and washcloths.

15 MIN

☐

7

Out the door. Take out the Toss and Donate boxes, and dispose of medicines (page 5 of this week). Count.

15 MIN

☐

Map Your Bathroom

Every bathroom hides its clutter in different places. Write in each drawer, cabinet and shelf you have, choose a day for it and check the boxes as you go.

SPACE	DAY	EMPTIED	SORTED	BACK IN PLACE
Counter and sink		☐	☐	☐
Medicine cabinet or shelf		☐	☐	☐
Under the sink		☐	☐	☐
Makeup and skin care drawer		☐	☐	☐
Hair and tools drawer		☐	☐	☐
Shower and tub		☐	☐	☐
Towel shelf or linen area		☐	☐	☐
Behind the door or on the toilet tank		☐	☐	☐
		☐	☐	☐
		☐	☐	☐
		☐	☐	☐
		☐	☐	☐

The space I'm dreading most: _____

What I hope it looks like by Day 7: _____

What the Bathroom Keeps

Count what you have before you decide. Seeing five of the same thing written down makes the decision easier. In the last column, write what you did with the extras.

ITEM	FOUND	KEEP	EXTRAS GO TO
Toothbrushes and toothpaste tubes			
Bars and bottles of soap			
Shampoo and conditioner			
Body wash and lotion			
Razors and shaving supplies			
Hairbrushes and combs			
Towels and washcloths			
Bath mats			
Hotel and sample sizes			
First aid supplies			

Something I own two or more of that I didn't realize: _____

Check the Date

Some things have a date on them, and some only have a rule of thumb. Use the table to decide, then log what you find below it.

ITEM	WHAT TO CHECK	THEN
Medicines (prescription and over-the-counter)	The expiration date printed on the label or package.	Expired or no longer needed: see the disposal page. Unsure? Ask your pharmacist.
Sunscreen	The printed expiration date. In the U.S., sunscreen is regulated as a drug, so it normally carries one.	Past its date, or you can't find a date: Toss. Write the purchase date on new ones with a marker.
Makeup and skin care	No U.S. law requires an expiration date on cosmetics. Makers usually suggest replacing mascara two to four months after you buy it. If a product smells, looks or feels different than it used to, or you can't remember when you bought it, let it go.	Toss. Write the open date on new ones with a marker.

This is general information, not medical advice. Sources: U.S. Food and Drug Administration (fda.gov).

ITEM I CHECKED	DATE ON IT (OR GUESS)	KEEP	TOSS

Getting Rid of Old Medicines

Don't toss pills in the trash loose, and don't flush any medicine unless it is on the FDA flush list. The U.S. Food and Drug Administration (FDA) recommends these options, in this order.

1. Use a drug take-back option when you can. Take-back locations are often at a local pharmacy or a police station, and the U.S. Drug Enforcement Administration (DEA) website can find one near you by zip code. Another option is a prepaid drug mail-back envelope, which you fill, seal and drop at any U.S. Post Office or postal drop box.

2. No take-back option? Check the flush list. A short list of medicines, such as some opioids, can be dangerous with a single dose if a child or pet gets to them. If your medicine is on the FDA flush list (on the FDA page named below), flush it right away. Flush only what is on that list.

3. Not on the flush list? Use the household trash. Mix the medicine with something unappealing, such as dirt, cat litter or used coffee grounds. Don't crush pills. Put the mixture in a sealed plastic bag and throw it away.

Before you recycle or toss the empty packaging, scratch out your name and other personal information on the prescription label. Sprays, inhalers and other unusual forms can have their own instructions: check the paper that came with the medicine or ask your pharmacist.

Source: FDA, "Disposal of Unused Medicines: What You Should Know," [fda.gov/drugs/safe-disposal-medicines/disposal-unused-medicines-what-you-should-know](https://www.fda.gov/drugs/safe-disposal-medicines/disposal-unused-medicines-what-you-should-know). Check that page for the current flush list. This is general information, not medical advice.

- ☐ I checked the flush list for any medicine I'm getting rid of
- ☐ I found a take-back location or mail-back option
- ☐ I removed or covered personal information on the labels

Take-back location near me: _____

The day I'll drop it off: _____ / _____ / _____

Where It's Going This Week

Decide where each box is headed while the room is fresh in your mind. A box that has a destination actually leaves the house.

D DONATE

Unopened toiletries and towels in good shape. Check what the place accepts before you go.

Where it's going: _____

The day I'll drop it off: _____ / _____ / _____

S SELL

Only what is worth at least your sell threshold from Week 0. In the bathroom, that is rare.

Where I'll list it: _____

T TOSS

Expired products, empty bottles, worn towels and anything you can't donate. Recycle what you can.

What needs special handling: _____

Keep / Donate / Sell / Toss Count

Each day, write how many items went into each box. Then add up the week.

	KEEP	DONATE	SELL	TOSS
Day 1				
Day 2				
Day 3				
Day 4				
Day 5				
Day 6				
Day 7				
TOTAL				

Estimated value of Sell items: \$ _____ Value of Donate items: \$ _____

Minutes this week: _____ Items out (Donate + Sell + Toss): _____

NOTES

WINS

WEEK
02

The Entryway and Coat Closet

The entryway is the first thing you see when you come home and the last thing you pass on the way out. It is also where everything lands: coats, shoes, bags, keys, mail, the umbrella you used once. Because it is small and busy, clutter builds up here faster than almost anywhere else.

This week you will work through it one layer at a time: the coat closet first, then shoes, bags, small accessories and finally keys and mail. Take everything out of one space, put it on the floor or a table and sort it into the four boxes: Keep, Donate, Sell, Toss. Coats take the most room, so start there. A coat nobody has worn in two winters is taking up room a coat you wear needs.

The last step is the one that keeps the entryway clear. By Day 6 you will set up a landing zone: one spot for everything that comes into the house, so it stops spreading to the counter and the stairs. The pages ahead help you plan it. Each day, stop at the timer and leave the rest for tomorrow.

WEEK 2 · THE ENTRYWAY AND COAT CLOSET

This Week, 15 Minutes a Day

- 1 **Coat closet, coats.** Take out every coat and jacket. Try on the ones you doubt. Sort. 15 MIN ☐
- 2 **Shoes.** Gather every pair from the entry, closet and doorway. Keep the pairs you wear. Sort the rest. 15 MIN ☐
- 3 **Bags, backpacks and totes.** Empty each one as you go. Keep only what you carry. 15 MIN ☐
- 4 **Hats, gloves, scarves and umbrellas.** Match up pairs. A single glove goes to Toss. 15 MIN ☐
- 5 **Keys and mail.** Sort the mail pile, then the key hooks, bowls and drawers. 15 MIN ☐
- 6 **Landing zone.** Choose the spot and set it up with the plan on page 5 of this week. 15 MIN ☐
- 7 **Out the door.** Take out the Toss and Donate boxes, and list anything for Sell. Count. 15 MIN ☐

Map Your Entryway

Write in each space where things pile up by the door, choose a day for it and check the boxes as you go.

SPACE	DAY	EMPTIED	SORTED	BACK IN PLACE
Coat closet		☐	☐	☐
Shoe rack or floor by the door		☐	☐	☐
Hooks and pegs		☐	☐	☐
Bench or console table		☐	☐	☐
Bag and backpack spot		☐	☐	☐
Key hooks, bowls and trays		☐	☐	☐
Mail pile and paper spot		☐	☐	☐
Drawer or basket by the door		☐	☐	☐
		☐	☐	☐
		☐	☐	☐
		☐	☐	☐
		☐	☐	☐

The spot that collects the most stuff: _____

What I want the doorway to feel like on Day 7: _____

Coats, Shoes and Bags

Write down what you have before you decide. Count one by one, then keep what you wear in a normal week. Seeing ten jackets on paper makes it easier to let a few go. In the last column, write where the extras are headed.

ITEM	FOUND	KEEP	EXTRAS GO TO
Winter coats			
Light jackets and rain jackets			
Shoes I wear every week			
Boots			
Sandals and flip-flops			
Shoes that hurt or don't fit			
Handbags and purses			
Backpacks and tote bags			
Gym and travel bags			
Hats, gloves and scarves			
Umbrellas			

A coat or pair of shoes I kept for “someday”: _____

Keys, Mail and Paper

Keys and mail are small, but they are the reason a doorway never looks clear. Sort the pile once, then decide where each kind of thing will go from now on.

WHAT I FOUND	KEEP	DONATE	SELL	TOSS
Keys I can't match to a lock				
Spare keys with no label				
Loose change and receipts				
Junk mail and flyers				
Catalogs and magazines				
Coupons and cards that have expired				
Bills and important papers				
Sunglasses, chargers, odds and ends				

Mail that needs an answer goes here: _____

Mail I can stop receiving (write what to cancel): _____

The day I'll sort mail every week: _____

Plan Your Landing Zone

A landing zone is one place for everything that comes into your home: keys, mail, bags and the things you need when you leave. The goal is simple. If it comes in through the door, it has a spot by the door, and nothing else comes further in without a reason.

WHAT LANDS HERE	WHERE IT GOES	WHO USES IT
Keys		
Mail		
Bags and backpacks		
Everyday shoes		
Coats worn this week		
Outgoing items (returns, donations)		

The spot I picked for my landing zone: _____

Something that will stay out of the entry: _____

- ☐ Every member of the household knows where their things go
- ☐ Keys have one hook, bowl or tray
- ☐ The mail has a place, and I picked a day to sort it
- ☐ The floor by the door is clear

Where It's Going This Week

Decide where each box is headed while the room is fresh in your mind. A box that has a destination actually leaves the house.

D DONATE

Coats, boots and bags in good shape, and pairs of gloves. Check what the place accepts before you go.

Where it's going: _____

The day I'll drop it off: _____ / _____ / _____

S SELL

Coats, bags and shoes worth at least your sell threshold from Week 0. Photograph them in daylight.

Where I'll list it: _____

T TOSS

Worn-out shoes, single gloves, broken umbrellas, expired coupons and junk mail. Recycle paper and what you can.

What needs special handling: _____

Keep / Donate / Sell / Toss Count

Each day, write how many items went into each box. Then add up the week.

	KEEP	DONATE	SELL	TOSS
Day 1				
Day 2				
Day 3				
Day 4				
Day 5				
Day 6				
Day 7				
TOTAL				

Estimated value of Sell items: \$ _____ Value of Donate items: \$ _____

Minutes this week: _____ Items out (Donate + Sell + Toss): _____

NOTES

WINS



Kitchen, Part One: Counters, Pantry and Fridge

The kitchen is the room you use the most, so it collects the most. To keep it from feeling like too much, it is split across two weeks. This week covers surfaces and food: counters, pantry, fridge and freezer. Week 4 handles cabinets, gadgets and containers.

The goal is simple: empty counters. Keep out only what you touch every day, like the coffee maker or the dish soap. Everything else needs a home in a cabinet or goes into a box.

Food is a little different. Nobody feels guilty about tossing a stale cracker, but many of us hesitate over food that is still good. Sealed, unexpired food you won't eat can go to Donate. Call your local food bank first and ask what they accept. Open packages and anything spoiled or that you won't eat go to Toss. Date labels mostly describe quality, not safety, and the pantry page shows how to check.

Work one zone a day. Take everything out, wipe the shelf and sort as you put things back.

WEEK 3 · KITCHEN, PART ONE: COUNTERS, PANTRY AND FRIDGE

This Week, 15 Minutes a Day

- 1

Counters, part one. Clear the main counter. Put back only what you use every day.

15 MIN ☐
- 2

Counters, part two. Small appliances, the paper pile, the fruit bowl and the corner nobody looks at.

15 MIN ☐
- 3

Pantry, top shelves. Take everything out. Check the dates. Set aside what is past its date or looks off.

15 MIN ☐
- 4

Pantry, lower shelves. Sort, and group duplicates together.

15 MIN ☐
- 5

Fridge. Shelves, door and drawers. Toss anything spoiled, unsafe or that you know you won't eat.

15 MIN ☐
- 6

Freezer and spices. Anything you can't identify or won't eat goes. Check the spice dates.

15 MIN ☐
- 7

Out the door. Take out the Toss and Donate boxes, bring the food donation to a drop-off, and count.

15 MIN ☐

Map Your Kitchen Zones

Write in each counter, shelf and storage spot you will sort this week. Choose a day for it and check the boxes as you go.

SPACE	DAY	EMPTIED	SORTED	BACK IN PLACE
Main counter		☐	☐	☐
Other counters and the corner		☐	☐	☐
Pantry, top shelves		☐	☐	☐
Pantry, lower shelves		☐	☐	☐
Refrigerator shelves and door		☐	☐	☐
Refrigerator drawers		☐	☐	☐
Freezer		☐	☐	☐
Spice rack or spice drawer		☐	☐	☐
		☐	☐	☐
		☐	☐	☐
		☐	☐	☐
		☐	☐	☐

The space I'm dreading most: _____

What I want my counters to look like by Day 7: _____

Clear the Counters

Put everything that lives on your counters in the list below. Then decide if it earns its place there. A good test: did you use it in the last week?

ON MY COUNTER	USE DAILY?	STAYS OUT	IF NOT, IT GOES TO

The one thing I’m surprised was out: _____

- ☐ Counters are wiped and clear except for my daily items
- ☐ Mail and loose paper have a spot (paper gets sorted in Week 9)
- ☐ Everything I use daily has a place to come back to

Pantry: Check, Count, Combine

Go through each shelf and look at the dates. Most are “best if used by” or “use by” dates, which tell you about quality, not safety. When a date is past, look at the food: if it smells or looks off, or the package is open and stale, let it go. Write down duplicates so you stop buying a fourth jar of the same thing.

PANTRY ITEM	FOUND	EXPIRED	KEEP	DONATE
Canned vegetables and beans				
Soup and broth				
Pasta and rice				
Cereal and oatmeal				
Baking supplies				
Sauces and condiments				
Snacks				
Oils and vinegars				
Coffee, tea and drinks				

Something I have three or more of: _____

Something I bought and never opened: _____

Apart from infant formula, federal law does not require food makers to put a date on their products, so a date is usually the maker's estimate of quality. For more on food date labels, see the U.S. Department of Agriculture Food Safety and Inspection Service (fsis.usda.gov).

Fridge, Freezer and the Food Bank

Go shelf by shelf. Toss what is moldy, smells off or is unrecognizable. Whatever is still good but you know you won't eat, such as sealed, unexpired pantry items, can go to a food bank. Fresh and opened food usually can't be donated.

FRIDGE OR FREEZER ITEM	DATE OR HOW OLD	KEEP	TOSS

Before you donate food

- ☐ I called or checked the website of a food bank or pantry near me
- ☐ I asked what they accept and when they take donations
- ☐ Everything I'm giving is sealed and within its date

Food bank or pantry I'll use: _____

The day I'll drop it off: _____ / _____ / _____

Where It's Going This Week

Decide where each box is headed while the room is fresh in your mind. A box that has a destination actually leaves the house.

D DONATE

Sealed, unexpired food for a food bank, plus working dishes and small appliances worth less than your sell threshold. Check what the place accepts before you go.

Where it's going: _____

The day I'll drop it off: _____ / _____ / _____

S SELL

Small appliances in good shape. Only what is worth at least your sell threshold from Week 0.

Where I'll list it: _____

T TOSS

Spoiled food, opened food you won't use, stale spices, freezer-burned items and broken gadgets. Recycle the packaging you can.

What needs special handling: _____

Keep / Donate / Sell / Toss Count

Each day, write how many items went into each box. Then add up the week.

	KEEP	DONATE	SELL	TOSS
Day 1				
Day 2				
Day 3				
Day 4				
Day 5				
Day 6				
Day 7				
TOTAL				

Estimated value of Sell items: \$ _____ Value of Donate items: \$ _____

Minutes this week: _____ Items out (Donate + Sell + Toss): _____

NOTES

WINS

WEEK
04

Kitchen, Part Two: Cabinets, Gadgets and Containers

Last week you cleared what you can see and what you eat. This week is the clutter behind the doors. Cabinets and drawers are where the waffle maker, the third set of measuring cups and the lids with no containers end up, and because you can't see them, you rarely decide about them.

Here is the test for every tool and gadget: did you use it in the last year? If yes, it stays and goes back where you can reach it. If no, it leaves, unless you only need it once a year and can name the day. Keep the duplicate you like best. Most items this week will be Donate, and a few good pieces may reach your sell threshold from Week 0.

Work one cabinet or drawer a day. Take everything out, wipe the shelf and put back only what passes the test. Don't buy organizers; space usually shows up once the extras are gone.

WEEK 4 · KITCHEN, PART TWO: CABINETS, GADGETS AND CONTAINERS

This Week, 15 Minutes a Day

- 1 **Everyday dishes and glasses.** Plates, bowls, mugs and cups. Keep what your household really uses. 15 MIN ☐
- 2 **Pots, pans and bakeware.** Lids, cookie sheets, muffin tins and the pan that's been warped for years. 15 MIN ☐
- 3 **Utensil and gadget drawers.** Apply the "used it in the last year?" test to every item. 15 MIN ☐
- 4 **Small appliances.** Blenders, mixers, slow cookers and the one you bought for a single recipe. 15 MIN ☐
- 5 **Food storage containers.** Match every lid to a container. Sort the ones with no match. 15 MIN ☐
- 6 **Serving pieces and special-occasion items.** Platters, pitchers, holiday dishes, extra glasses. 15 MIN ☐
- 7 **Out the door.** Take out the Toss and Donate boxes. List any Sell items. Count. 15 MIN ☐

Map Your Kitchen Cabinets

Write in each cabinet, drawer and shelf you'll go through, choose a day for it and check the boxes as you go.

SPACE	DAY	EMPTIED	SORTED	BACK IN PLACE
Dish and glass cabinet		☐	☐	☐
Pots and pans cabinet		☐	☐	☐
Bakeware and sheet pans		☐	☐	☐
Utensil drawer		☐	☐	☐
Gadget or “junk” drawer		☐	☐	☐
Small appliance shelf		☐	☐	☐
Food storage container cabinet		☐	☐	☐
Top shelves and hard-to-reach corners		☐	☐	☐
		☐	☐	☐
		☐	☐	☐
		☐	☐	☐
		☐	☐	☐

The cabinet I open and sigh at: _____

What I want to reach for without moving anything: _____

Used It in the Last Year?

Pick up each item and ask the question out loud. If you can't remember the last time, the answer is no. Write down items that make you hesitate, then decide.

ITEM	KEEP	DONATE	SELL	TOSS
Waffle maker, juicer, bread machine				
Extra spatulas, ladles and whisks				
Gadgets with one job (egg slicer, avocado tool)				
Mismatched or chipped mugs and glasses				
Baking pans you never bake in				
Extra measuring cups and spoons				
Cookbooks and recipe printouts				
Plastic cups and takeout utensils				

Something I kept “just in case” and never used: _____

Something I’m glad I rediscovered: _____

Containers and Lids

A container without a lid, or a lid without a container, is not doing a job. Match them all, then sort. Stack the pairs, and put the rest in the Toss or recycling box.

CONTAINER TYPE	PAIRS	LOOSE
Glass containers		
Plastic containers		
Reusable bags and wraps		
Water bottles and travel mugs		
Jars and takeout tubs		

- ☐ I matched every lid to a container
- ☐ I set aside lids and containers with no match
- ☐ I tossed or recycled warped, stained, cracked or scratched plastic
- ☐ I kept only as many containers as fit back in one cabinet
- ☐ I gave away the travel mugs and water bottles I don't use

The number of containers I kept: _____

The number I'm letting go of: _____

Small Appliances

Small appliances take up a lot of room. Give each one a simple decision. Write down the last time you used it and choose.

APPLIANCE	LAST TIME I USED IT	KEEP	DONATE	SELL	TOSS

Before you donate or sell an appliance, unplug it, wipe it down and check that it works. Include the cord, and any parts that belong with it. Something that doesn't work, or that is missing parts, goes in Toss. Check your local guidelines for electronics disposal.

The one appliance I use every week: _____

Where It's Going This Week

Decide where each box is headed while the kitchen is fresh in your mind. A box that has a destination actually leaves the house.

D DONATE

Dishes, cookware and gadgets in good shape and complete. Check what the place accepts before you go.

Where it's going: _____

The day I'll drop it off: _____ / _____ / _____

S SELL

Anything worth at least your sell threshold from Week 0: a working stand mixer, name-brand cookware, sets still in the box.

Where I'll list it: _____

T TOSS

Cracked dishes, warped plastic, broken gadgets and lids with no match. Wrap sharp or broken glass before it goes in the bin.

What needs special handling: _____

Keep / Donate / Sell / Toss Count

Each day, write how many items went into each box. Then add up the week.

	KEEP	DONATE	SELL	TOSS
Day 1				
Day 2				
Day 3				
Day 4				
Day 5				
Day 6				
Day 7				
TOTAL				

Estimated value of Sell items: \$ _____ Value of Donate items: \$ _____

Minutes this week: _____ Items out (Donate + Sell + Toss): _____

NOTES

WINS



The Living Room

The living room belongs to everyone, which is why it fills up so easily. The remote that belongs to no one, the stack of magazines from last spring, the drawer of cables for devices you no longer own: each one got there because it was easier to set down than to decide about.

This week you work in zones: the media area, the shelves, the coffee table and side tables, and the decorations. Take one zone at a time, sort every item into the four boxes (Keep, Donate, Sell, Toss) and put the Keep items back in a place that makes sense. Old electronics, DVDs and books may reach your sell threshold from Week 0. Check what a device does before you donate it, and wipe personal data first.

This is also the one room you don't decide alone. On page 5 of this week, you and the people you live with agree on what stays in the living room. Ask before you toss anything that isn't yours.

WEEK 5 · THE LIVING ROOM

This Week, 15 Minutes a Day

- | | | |
|---|---|---------------------------------|
| 1 | Media area. Game consoles, players, speakers and the shelf under the TV. Note what still works and gets used. | 15 MIN ☐ |
| 2 | Cables, chargers and remotes. Match each one to a device you own. Toss the rest or take it to electronics recycling. | 15 MIN ☐ |
| 3 | Movies, music and games. Discs, cases and games your household no longer plays. | 15 MIN ☐ |
| 4 | Magazines, books and papers. Keep the issue you are reading. Recycle the rest. Books can go to Donate or Sell. | 15 MIN ☐ |
| 5 | Coffee table and side tables. Clear every surface. Empty the drawers. | 15 MIN ☐ |
| 6 | Decor, blankets and pillows. Keep what you like to look at and use. Check the baskets and the sofa cushions. | 15 MIN ☐ |
| 7 | Out the door. Take out the Toss and Donate boxes. Hold a family check-in (page 5 of this week). Count. | 15 MIN ☐ |

Map Your Living Room

List each zone, shelf and drawer, choose a day for it and check the boxes as you go.

ZONE	DAY	EMPTIED	SORTED	BACK IN PLACE
TV stand and media shelf		☐	☐	☐
Cable and charger basket or drawer		☐	☐	☐
Bookshelves		☐	☐	☐
Movie, music and game storage		☐	☐	☐
Magazine rack or basket		☐	☐	☐
Coffee table and side tables		☐	☐	☐
Decor, frames and mantel		☐	☐	☐
Blankets, pillows and baskets		☐	☐	☐
		☐	☐	☐
		☐	☐	☐
		☐	☐	☐
		☐	☐	☐

The zone that bothers me most: _____

What I want to do in this room: _____

Media, Cables and Remotes

Match every cable, charger and remote to a device you own. If you can't name the device, put the item aside for a week. If nothing has missed it by the end of Week 5, it goes in Toss or an electronics recycling drop-off.

ITEM	FOUND	KEEP	THE REST GOES TO
Remotes			
Phone and tablet chargers			
Power cords and adapters			
HDMI and other video cables			
Headphones and earbuds			
Old phones and tablets			
Game consoles and controllers			
Speakers and players			
Batteries (loose)			
Extension cords and power strips			

Batteries, old phones and other electronics often have special drop-off rules. Check your local guidelines. Erase personal data before you donate or sell a device.

A device I own that I'd forgotten about: _____

Discs, Books and Magazines

A shelf full of things you finished, or never started, takes up space you can see. Ask of each one: would I pick this up again? Then sort.

WHAT I FOUND	KEEP	DONATE	SELL	TOSS
Movies and TV seasons				
Music and audio discs				
Video games				
Board games and puzzles				
Books I've read				
Books I haven't read				
Magazines and catalogs				
Manuals and warranty booklets				

The one magazine or book pile I'll stop at: _____

Where unread books can wait, and for how long: _____

What Stays in the Living Room

This room is shared, so decide together. Sit down with the people you live with for a few minutes, read the list below aloud, and write down the answers. Nothing needs to be perfect. You can change it at your 15-minute reset.

ITEM OR CATEGORY	STAYS HERE?	WHO DECIDES
Board games and toys		
Blankets and pillows		
Personal books and hobby items		
Chargers and devices		
Decor and family photos		
Shoes, bags and mail		

- ☐ We agreed on a place for remotes and chargers
- ☐ We agreed what gets put away at the end of the day
- ☐ I asked before I removed anything that isn't mine

The one rule for this room we all agree on: _____

The day we'll check in again: _____ / _____ / _____

Where It's Going This Week

Decide where each box is headed while the room is fresh in your mind. A box that has a destination actually leaves the house.

D DONATE

Books, movies, games and working electronics in good shape. Check what the place accepts before you go.

Where it's going: _____

The day I'll drop it off: _____ / _____ / _____

S SELL

Anything worth at least your sell threshold from Week 0: games, consoles, larger electronics and collections.

Where I'll list it: _____

T TOSS

Tangled cables, dead remotes, broken electronics and old magazines. Recycle what you can, and check local guidelines for electronics.

What needs special handling: _____

Keep / Donate / Sell / Toss Count

Each day, write how many items went into each box. Then add up the week.

	KEEP	DONATE	SELL	TOSS
Day 1				
Day 2				
Day 3				
Day 4				
Day 5				
Day 6				
Day 7				
TOTAL				

Estimated value of Sell items: \$ _____ Value of Donate items: \$ _____

Minutes this week: _____ Items out (Donate + Sell + Toss): _____

NOTES

WINS

WEEK 06

Your Bedroom

The bedroom is the room you see first in the morning and last at night, so what sits in it gets noticed more than you think. The nightstand drawer that holds six pens and no paper, the box pushed under the bed “for now,” the chair that has turned into a second closet: none of it was a decision. It just landed.

This week you clear the spots where things pile up. Take them one at a time: the nightstands, the space under the bed, the clothes chair, the dresser top and the floor and corners. Sort every item into the four boxes: Keep, Donate, Sell, Toss. Clothes get their own week, so this week you only deal with the ones sitting out of place. Anything you pull from under the bed that you haven’t seen in a year deserves a hard look.

You also get a page to describe how you want the room to look. Write it down before you start, and check it again on Day 7.

WEEK 6 · YOUR BEDROOM

This Week, 15 Minutes a Day

- 1 **First nightstand.** Empty the top and the drawer. Keep only what you use at night. 15 MIN ☐
- 2 **Second nightstand or bedside table.** Same thing. If you have only one, start the dresser top. 15 MIN ☐
- 3 **Under the bed.** Pull everything out, look at each item and sort it. Log it on page 3 of this week. 15 MIN ☐
- 4 **The clothes chair.** Sort the pile into clean, dirty and “not sure.” Use page 4 of this week. 15 MIN ☐
- 5 **Dresser top and windowsill.** Trays, jewelry dishes, loose change, receipts and old perfume bottles. 15 MIN ☐
- 6 **Floor, corners and walls.** Baskets, shoes, books, decor and anything that landed and stayed. 15 MIN ☐
- 7 **Out the door.** Take out the Toss and Donate boxes. Look at page 5 of this week and write down what you see. Count. 15 MIN ☐

Map Your Bedroom

Every bedroom collects things in its own places. Write in yours, choose a day for each and check the boxes as you go.

SPACE	DAY	EMPTIED	SORTED	BACK IN PLACE
First nightstand (top and drawer)		☐	☐	☐
Second nightstand or bedside table		☐	☐	☐
Under the bed		☐	☐	☐
The clothes chair		☐	☐	☐
Dresser top		☐	☐	☐
Windowsill or shelf		☐	☐	☐
Floor and corners		☐	☐	☐
Wall hooks and door		☐	☐	☐
		☐	☐	☐
		☐	☐	☐
		☐	☐	☐
		☐	☐	☐

The spot that bothers me most: _____

Something I've walked around for months: _____

Nightstands and Under the Bed

Put here what you found. The nightstand should hold what you reach for at night and nothing else. Under the bed should hold only things you can name.

WHAT I FOUND	KEEP	DONATE	SELL	TOSS
Nightstand: books and magazines				
Nightstand: pens, notepads, coins				
Nightstand: cords and chargers I use				
Nightstand: lotions, lip balm, loose items				
Under the bed: boxes and bins				
Under the bed: shoes and bags				
Under the bed: bedding and blankets				
Under the bed: things I can't name				

The one thing I'll keep within reach of the bed: _____

A box I hadn't opened in over a year held: _____

The Clothes Chair

The chair is not the problem. It is where “I’ll decide later” piles up. Go through the pile one item at a time and give each piece a home. The full wardrobe decisions wait for Week 7.

ITEM ON THE CHAIR	CLEAN	DIRTY	WHERE IT BELONGS
Worn once, not dirty enough to wash			
Clean clothes never put away			
Clothes waiting to be washed			
Pajamas and robes			
Items to try on before deciding			
Things that need mending			

- ☐ The chair is empty, or it holds only what I wore today
- ☐ Dirty clothes are in the hamper or the laundry room
- ☐ Anything I’m “not sure” about is in a bag marked for Week 7

Why things land on the chair: _____

How I Want My Bedroom to Look

Describe how you want the room to look and feel, then compare it with what you see on Day 7. Write what you would notice when you walk in: what's on the surfaces, what's on the floor, what's in view from the bed.

Right now I see:

I want to see:

- ☐ The nightstands hold only what I use each night
- ☐ Nothing is stored under the bed that I can't name
- ☐ Every surface has at most three things on it
- ☐ I like what I see from the bed

One thing that still needs to move out: _____

Day 7 date: _____ / _____ / _____

Where It's Going This Week

Decide where each box is headed while the room is fresh in your mind. A box that has a destination actually leaves the house.

D DONATE

Books, unopened toiletries, bedding and decor in good shape. Check what the place accepts before you go.

Where it's going: _____

The day I'll drop it off: _____ / _____ / _____

S SELL

Furniture, lamps, frames and anything worth at least your sell threshold from Week 0.

Where I'll list it: _____

T TOSS

Broken items, dried-out pens, worn pillows, old receipts and anything you can't donate. Recycle what you can.

What needs special handling: _____

Keep / Donate / Sell / Toss Count

Each day, write how many items went into each box. Then add up the week.

	KEEP	DONATE	SELL	TOSS
Day 1				
Day 2				
Day 3				
Day 4				
Day 5				
Day 6				
Day 7				
TOTAL				

Estimated value of Sell items: \$ _____ Value of Donate items: \$ _____

Minutes this week: _____ Items out (Donate + Sell + Toss): _____

NOTES

WINS



The Closet

The closet is the biggest week in the book, and the most rewarding. Clothes take up more room than almost anything else in the house, and they are some of the easiest things to sell. Some of the pieces you no longer wear may be worth \$20 or more to someone else.

The work is simple. Take everything out of one section at a time, look at each piece and sort it into the four boxes: Keep, Donate, Sell, Toss. To help, there are two quick tests. First, the reverse-hanger test: turn every hanger backward, and each time you wear something, hang it back the right way. Anything still backward after a month or two is telling you something. Second, the tie-breaker from the start of this book: if it were gone tomorrow, would you go out and buy it again?

Expect three groups to be tricky: clothes that don't fit, the "when I lose weight" clothes, and party clothes you wear once a year. Page 4 gives each group its own space. Pick up the "not sure" bag from Week 6 too. Anything worth at least your sell threshold goes to the Sell Tracker in Where It All Went.

WEEK 7 · THE CLOSET

This Week, 15 Minutes a Day

- 1

Set up. Clear a spot for the four boxes, then start the reverse-hanger test. Turn every hanger backward.

15 MIN ☐
- 2

Shirts and tops. Take out one section at a time. Try on anything you're unsure about.

15 MIN ☐
- 3

Pants, skirts and dresses. Sort each piece. Move the ones that don't fit to page 4 of this week.

15 MIN ☐
- 4

Jackets, sweaters and coats. Check the collars, cuffs and elbows. Keep what you reached for this year.

15 MIN ☐
- 5

Shoes and accessories. Belts, scarves, ties, hats and jewelry. Pair up shoes and check the soles.

15 MIN ☐
- 6

Party clothes and the "not sure" bag. Go through both. Use page 4 of this week.

15 MIN ☐
- 7

Out the door. Take out the Toss and Donate boxes. Log the Sell box in the Sell Tracker in Where It All Went. Count.

15 MIN ☐

Map Your Closet

Closets have sections, and each one gets its own day. Write in yours, choose a day for each and check the boxes as you go. Include the dresser too if clothes live there.

SPACE	DAY	EMPTIED	SORTED	BACK IN PLACE
Shirts and tops		☐	☐	☐
Pants, skirts and dresses		☐	☐	☐
Jackets, sweaters and coats		☐	☐	☐
Shoes		☐	☐	☐
Belts, scarves, ties and hats		☐	☐	☐
Jewelry and small accessories		☐	☐	☐
Dresser drawers		☐	☐	☐
Top shelf and floor		☐	☐	☐
		☐	☐	☐
		☐	☐	☐
		☐	☐	☐
		☐	☐	☐

The part of my closet I avoid opening: _____

What I wear most weeks: _____

The Reverse-Hanger Test

Turn every hanger so the hook faces the wrong way. When you wear a piece and wash it, hang it back the right way. After a month or two, look at what is still backward. Write it here and decide.

STILL BACKWARD AFTER _____ WEEKS	KEEP	DONATE	SELL	TOSS
Shirts and tops				
Pants and skirts				
Dresses				
Jackets and coats				
Sweaters				
Shoes (not worn since _____)				
Accessories				
Something I kept “just in case”				

Something I was sure I wore, but the hanger says otherwise: _____

The piece I reach for again and again: _____

Fit, “Someday” and Party Clothes

Three groups hold the most “maybe” in a closet. Be kind and honest: clothes that fit you now deserve the space, and so do you.

GROUP	KEEP	DONATE	SELL	TOSS
Doesn't fit right now				
Fit again “when I lose weight”				
Party and special-occasion clothes				
Clothes from an old job or life				
Still has the tags on				
From my “not sure” bag in Week 6				

- ☐ If it doesn't fit and I wouldn't buy it again, it goes out
- ☐ If I keep anything for a future size, it is no more than one small box
- ☐ Party clothes: I kept what I'd wear again and let go of the rest
- ☐ The “not sure” bag is empty or sorted

What I'll do with clothes I can't quite let go of: _____

What Sells, What Goes

Clothes are some of the most sellable things in your house. Use the page to plan the Sell box before you list anything. The list itself goes in the Sell Tracker in Where It All Went.

PIECE	SELL BOX	WORTH AT LEAST \$	IN THE SELL TRACKER

- ☐ Every piece in the Sell box is worth at least my sell threshold
- ☐ I checked each piece for stains, holes and missing buttons
- ☐ The pieces are listed in the Sell Tracker in Where It All Went
- ☐ Anything that didn't sell by my deadline moves to the Donate box

My deadline for selling: _____ / _____ / _____

Where I'll bring what doesn't sell: _____

Where It's Going This Week

Decide where each box is headed while the closet is fresh in your mind. A box that has a destination actually leaves the house.

D DONATE

Clean clothes in good shape, coats, shoes, belts and bags. A coat in winter is especially welcome. Check what the place accepts before you go.

Where it's going: _____

The day I'll drop it off: _____ / _____ / _____

S SELL

Anything worth at least your sell threshold from Week 0. Online marketplace, local consignment shop or a garage sale. Log each one in the Sell Tracker in Where It All Went.

Where I'll list it: _____

T TOSS

Stained, torn or worn-out pieces, single socks and shoes without a pair. Ask if your area has a textile recycling drop-off.

What needs special handling: _____

Keep / Donate / Sell / Toss Count

Each day, write how many items went into each box. Then add up the week.

	KEEP	DONATE	SELL	TOSS
Day 1				
Day 2				
Day 3				
Day 4				
Day 5				
Day 6				
Day 7				
TOTAL				

Estimated value of Sell items: \$ _____ Value of Donate items: \$ _____

Minutes this week: _____ Items out (Donate + Sell + Toss): _____

NOTES

WINS



Kids' Rooms and Toys (or the Hobby Room)

This week has two tracks. Pick the one that fits your home. If you have kids at home, take the kids' track. If you don't, take the hobby track: the craft table, the sewing corner, the tool bench, the half-finished projects.

On the kids' track, the goal is not a perfect playroom. It is a room a child can actually use. Many parents find that kids play longer with fewer choices out, so the plan is to keep a smaller set out and rotate the rest. Ask your child to help with each decision. Even a young child can say "keep" or "let go," and a child who helped choose often lets the toy go more easily. Never sneak anything out of the house. Trust is worth more than space.

On the hobby track, the goal is to find out what you still do. Supplies you bought for a hobby you dropped two years ago are not a promise. Stalled projects get a decision, not a guilt pile.

WEEK 8 · KIDS' ROOMS AND TOYS (OR THE HOBBY ROOM)

This Week, 15 Minutes a Day

- 1 **Choose a track.** Fill in page 2. Set up the four boxes, plus one bin or bag for "rotation" or "finish later." 15 MIN ☐
- 2 **Kids: sort out the obvious.** Broken toys, missing pieces, outgrown baby items. **Hobby:** dried-out paints, glue, markers. 15 MIN ☐
- 3 **Kids: decide together.** Sit on the floor with your child. Use page 3. **Hobby:** fabric, yarn, paper and kits. 15 MIN ☐
- 4 **Kids: books and games.** Check the ages on the box. **Hobby:** tools, patterns and how-to books. 15 MIN ☐
- 5 **Kids: toy rotation.** Set up the first round on page 4. **Hobby:** the stalled projects. Use page 5. 15 MIN ☐
- 6 **Kids: art supplies and the closet shelf.** **Hobby:** the work surface. Clear it, then put back only what you use. 15 MIN ☐
- 7 **Out the door.** Take out the Toss and Donate boxes. Log the Sell box in the Sell Tracker in Where It All Went. Count. 15 MIN ☐

Choose Your Track and Map the Space

Check one track. Then list the spaces you will go through, pick a day for each and check the boxes as you go.

- ☐ With kids: I'll use the kids' pages (3 and 4)
- ☐ Without kids: I'll use the hobby page (5)
- ☐ Both: I'll do the kids' pages first and the hobby page if time is left

SPACE	DAY	EMPTIED	SORTED	BACK IN PLACE
Toy bins and shelves				
Closet or under the bed				
Books and games				
Art and craft supplies				
Hobby table or shelves				
Boxes of unfinished projects				

The spot that holds the most “someday” stuff: _____

What gets used most in this room: _____

Kids' Track: Decide Together

Sit down with your child and go one group at a time. Hold up each item and ask the same two questions: "Do you play with this?" and "Would you like to give it to someone who will?" Let their answer stand, unless the item is broken or unsafe. Keep sessions short. Stop when attention runs out.

GROUP	KEEP	DONATE	SELL	TOSS
Outgrown toys and baby items				
Stuffed animals				
Puzzles and board games				
Dress-up and pretend play				
Building sets and loose pieces				
Toys from a party or gift bag				
Books read too many times, or never				

- ☐ My child helped decide on at least one group
- ☐ Nothing left the house without my child knowing
- ☐ My child picked a few favorites that always stay out
- ☐ Toys with missing pieces or broken parts are in Toss, or repaired

What my child was happy to let go of: _____

What surprised me: _____

Kids' Track: Toy Rotation

Keep one small set of toys out and store the rest out of sight. Every few weeks, swap a few back in. The old toys feel new again, and the room stays manageable. This works with the shelf, closet or bin you already have, so there is nothing to buy.

ROUND	OUT NOW	STORED FOR LATER
Round 1		
Round 2		
Round 3		
Round 4		

- ☐ Always out: the favorites my child picked
- ☐ The stored toys are in one spot and easy to reach
- ☐ I wrote the next swap date on the calendar
- ☐ A toy untouched for 3 rounds goes to Donate or Sell

Next swap date: _____ / _____ / _____

Where the stored toys live: _____

Hobby Track: Supplies and Stalled Projects

For each project or supply group, ask honestly: do I still want to do this? If yes, choose a finish date or a spot for the supplies. If no, let it go. A project you keep promising yourself is taking up space in your head as well as in the closet.

PROJECT OR SUPPLY GROUP	KEEP	DONATE	SELL	TOSS

- ☐ Every project I kept has a finish date or a place to live
- ☐ Supplies for a hobby I dropped are in Donate, Sell or Toss
- ☐ Dried-out paint, glue and markers are in Toss
- ☐ Anything I kept "to finish someday" fits in one box

The project I'll finish by: _____ / _____ / _____

The hobby I still love: _____

Where It's Going This Week

Decide where each box is headed while the room is fresh in your mind. A box that has a destination actually leaves the house.

D DONATE

Clean toys with all their pieces, books, games and craft supplies in good shape. Schools, daycares and community groups often take art supplies. Ask before you go.

Where it's going: _____

The day I'll drop it off: _____ / _____ / _____

S SELL

Anything worth at least your sell threshold from Week 0. Craft supplies, musical instruments and sealed kits sell well. Online marketplace, local consignment shop or a garage sale. Log each one in the Sell Tracker in Where It All Went.

Where I'll list it: _____

T TOSS

Broken toys, toys with missing parts, dried-out supplies and scraps too small to use. Check your local guidelines for batteries and paints.

What needs special handling: _____

Keep / Donate / Sell / Toss Count

Each day, write how many items went into each box. Then add up the week.

	KEEP	DONATE	SELL	TOSS
Day 1				
Day 2				
Day 3				
Day 4				
Day 5				
Day 6				
Day 7				
TOTAL				

Estimated value of Sell items: \$ _____ Value of Donate items: \$ _____

Minutes this week: _____ Items out (Donate + Sell + Toss): _____

NOTES

WINS



The Home Office and the Paper Pile

Paper stalls a lot of people. Each sheet feels like a small decision, and there are hundreds of them. So this week runs on rules, not on feelings. Once you know how long a document matters, most of the pile decides itself.

Start with the desk, not the pile. Clear the surface and the drawers first, so you have room to work. Then go through the paper in one direction: one stack at a time, every sheet into Keep, Shred, Recycle or “Needs action.” Shred and Recycle both count as Toss. Do not read what you can skip. If a sheet needs an action, do it in the next 15 minutes or write the task down and move on.

Page 3 lists how long to keep common documents. Page 4 sorts what to scan and what to shred. When a sheet is not on either list, ask: “Could I get this again online or by phone?” If yes, it can go.

WEEK 9 · THE HOME OFFICE AND THE PAPER PILE

This Week, 15 Minutes a Day

1

Set up the four boxes, plus a shred bag and a “needs action” folder. Clear the desk surface and put back only what you use daily.

15 MIN

☐

2

Desk drawers and supplies. Dead pens, dried-out markers, old cables, loose sticky notes. Keep one set of each.

15 MIN

☐

3

The newest stack. Mail and papers from the last 30 days. Sort each sheet. Do the “needs action” items now.

15 MIN

☐

4

The oldest stack. Start with the bottom of the pile. Use pages 3 and 4 for the rules.

15 MIN

☐

5

Files and folders. Empty the file drawer or box. Toss what has passed its time on page 3.

15 MIN

☐

6

Manuals, cords and equipment. Printer, router, old chargers. Manuals are almost always online.

15 MIN

☐

7

Out the door. Take out the Toss and Donate boxes. Shred what is in the shred bag. Count.

15 MIN

☐

Map Your Office and the Paper Pile

List each place paper piles up. Pick a day for each one and check the boxes as you go.

PLACE	DAY	EMPTIED	SORTED	BACK IN PLACE
Desk surface				
Desk drawers				
File drawer or file box				
Mail pile or basket				
Shelves and bookcase				
Computer desktop and downloads				
Bags, bins and boxes of papers				

The pile I'm avoiding most: _____

The paper I handle every week: _____

What I never seem to find when I need it: _____

How Long to Keep Your Papers

Here is what the IRS says about tax records, and some general habits for the rest. This is information, not tax advice. Your situation may differ, so check with a tax professional.

DOCUMENT	HOW LONG
Tax returns and the records behind them (income, deductions, credits)	IRS: generally 3 years from the date you filed. Many people also keep the return itself longer.
Records if you did not report income that was more than 25% of the gross income on your return	IRS: 6 years
Records for a bad debt or worthless securities claim	IRS: 7 years
Records if you never filed a return, or filed a fraudulent one	IRS: no end date. Keep them indefinitely.
Employment tax records (for example, for a household employee)	IRS: at least 4 years after the tax is due or paid
Records for a home or other property you own	IRS: until the limitations period ends for the year you sell or dispose of it
Monthly bills and receipts for small purchases	General habit, not a rule: until paid and the next statement matches. Keep any that support a tax deduction as long as that return.
Warranties and manuals	General habit, not a rule: until the warranty ends or you no longer own the item. Keep the receipt with it.
Insurance policies, loan papers, deeds, wills	Ask the company or a professional. Many people keep these as long as they are in effect.

Source: IRS, “How long should I keep records?” ([irs.gov](https://www.irs.gov)). Insurers and lenders can ask you to keep records longer than the IRS does.

What to Scan, What to Shred

A scan is worth it for papers you might need again but do not need to hold. A shred bag is for anything with your name and account details on it. Whatever you scan, back it up in a second place.

PAPER	KEEP PAPER	SCAN	SHRED	RECYCLE
Bank and credit card statements				
Pay stubs and benefit letters				
Medical bills and explanation of benefits				
Receipts for big purchases				
Utility bills, once paid				
Junk mail and pre-approved offers				
Old checks and deposit slips				
Expired cards and old insurance cards				

- ☐ Anything with an account number, Social Security number or birth date that I don't need to keep goes in the shred bag
- ☐ Originals I must keep as paper (birth certificates, deeds, titles) are in one folder
- ☐ Scans have clear names and are backed up in a second place
- ☐ I shredded or recycled only what was past its time on page 3

Set Up a Simple Paper System

You do not need a fancy system. You need three places, and a weekly habit that keeps them small. Use what you already have: a folder, a tray, a drawer.

PLACE	WHAT GOES HERE	WHERE IT LIVES
Needs action		
To file		
Keep for the year		
Long-term keep		

- ☐ There is one spot where new mail lands (see your landing zone from Week 2)
- ☐ I opened and sorted the mail the same day
- ☐ “Needs action” gets cleared on one set day each week
- ☐ Each file folder has a name I can read from across the desk

My weekly paper day: _____

Where the long-term folder lives: _____

Where It's Going This Week

Decide where each box is headed while the office is fresh in your mind. A box that has a destination actually leaves the house.

D DONATE

Books, binders and office supplies in good shape, working equipment with the data erased. Schools, libraries and community groups sometimes take supplies. Ask before you go.

Where it's going: _____

The day I'll drop it off: _____ / _____ / _____

S SELL

Anything worth at least your sell threshold from Week 0. A chair, a desk, a monitor or printer in working order. Online marketplace, local consignment shop or a garage sale. Log each one in the Sell Tracker in Where It All Went.

Where I'll list it: _____

T TOSS

Expired papers, old receipts and junk mail. Shred anything with personal details. Check your local guidelines for old electronics and ink cartridges.

What needs special handling: _____

Keep / Donate / Sell / Toss Count

Each day, write how many items went into each box. Then add up the week.

	KEEP	DONATE	SELL	TOSS
Day 1				
Day 2				
Day 3				
Day 4				
Day 5				
Day 6				
Day 7				
TOTAL				

Estimated value of Sell items: \$ _____ Value of Donate items: \$ _____

Minutes this week: _____ Items out (Donate + Sell + Toss): _____

NOTES

WINS

WEEK 10

Linen Closet, Laundry and Cleaning Supplies

Support closets fill up quietly. Nobody plans a shelf of mismatched sheets or a cabinet of half-used sprays. Things land there because the door closes and hides them. This week you open that door and decide what stays.

Work in three zones: the linen closet, the laundry area and the cleaning supplies. Empty one zone at a time so you can see what you really have, then sort into the four boxes. Clean, good towels and blankets can be Donate. Stained or torn ones can be Toss, or go in the rag bag if you really use rags. Sheets for a bed you no longer own are an easy yes for Donate. Keep extras only for guests you actually host.

Page 3 sets a number for sheets and towels. Page 4 covers cleaning products, and page 5 bridges to the *House Cleaning Checklist Planner*. One safety rule for the whole week: never mix cleaning products.

WEEK 10 · LINEN CLOSET, LAUNDRY AND CLEANING SUPPLIES

This Week, 15 Minutes a Day

- 1 **Set up the four boxes**, plus one bag for rags. Empty the top shelf of the linen closet and wipe it down. 15 MIN ☐
- 2 **Sheets and pillowcases**. Pull every set. Match sheets to beds. Sort what is left by size. 15 MIN ☐
- 3 **Towels and washcloths**. Toss the worn ones. Use page 3 for your number. 15 MIN ☐
- 4 **Blankets, pillows and comforters**. Check each for wear and fit. 15 MIN ☐
- 5 **The laundry area**. Empty baskets and the shelf above the machines. Sort lone socks. 15 MIN ☐
- 6 **Gather the cleaning products**. Bring every bottle to one table. Fill in page 4. 15 MIN ☐
- 7 **Out the door**. Take out the Toss and Donate boxes. Put the keepers back. Count. 15 MIN ☐

Map Your Linen Closet and Laundry Area

List each place where sheets, towels and supplies collect. Pick a day for each one and check the boxes as you go.

PLACE	DAY	EMPTIED	SORTED	BACK IN PLACE
Linen closet shelves				
Bed linens and pillows				
Bath towels and washcloths				
Laundry room or area				
Shelf or cabinet above the machines				
Under the bathroom sink				
Cleaning supply spot				

The shelf I open least: _____

Something in here I keep “just in case”: _____

What I wish I could reach more easily: _____

How Many Sets Is Enough?

Most homes keep more linens than they use. The numbers below are a starting point, not a rule. Change them for your household, then count what you have. Extras go in Donate or Toss.

ITEM	MY NUMBER	HAVE	EXTRA	TOSS
Sheet sets for each bed (one on, one to swap)				
Bath towels for each person				
Hand towels and washcloths				
Guest towels and a spare bed set				
Blankets and comforters per bed				
Pillows per bed, plus one spare				
Kitchen towels and dishcloths				
Beach towels				

- ☐ Every sheet set matches a bed I have now, and the set is complete
- ☐ Towels that are thin, frayed or stained are in the Toss or rag bag
- ☐ Extra linens in good condition are in the Donate box
- ☐ Anything worth at least my sell threshold is listed in the Sell Tracker

Cleaning Products: Gather and Check

Bring every cleaner, spray and refill to one table. You will find duplicates and bottles you forgot. Many products carry a date or a “best by” mark on the label. If there is no date, use what you know: a product that has separated, changed color or smells off is ready to go.

PRODUCT OR TYPE	KEEP	DONATE	SELL	TOSS
All-purpose and glass cleaners				
Bathroom and toilet cleaners				
Kitchen and oven cleaners				
Dish and laundry soap				
Sponges, brushes and cloths				
Air fresheners and polishes				
Half-empty bottles of the same product				
Products I never use				

- ☐ I checked every label for a date and tossed expired or unsafe-looking products
- ☐ Each product is in its original container with the label readable
- ☐ I did not mix products, and I will not mix them while pouring leftovers together
- ☐ For anything hazardous, I will check my local household hazardous waste guidelines before it leaves the house

From Supplies to a Cleaning Routine

What you kept now has a home. The *House Cleaning Checklist Planner* turns that shelf into a simple routine, room by room, in 15-minute blocks. Use this page to set up the supplies so the routine is easy to start.

CLEANING JOB	WHAT I USE	WHERE IT LIVES
Glass and mirrors		
Bathroom		
Kitchen		
Floors		
Dusting		
Laundry		

- ☐ I keep the supplies for each room where I use them, if space allows
- ☐ A caddy or bucket holds a short list, not every bottle I own
- ☐ Refills and backups stay in one place, not spread across the house
- ☐ I have a day each week when I check what is running low

The one cleaning job I want to do weekly: _____

Where my supplies live now: _____

Where It's Going This Week

Decide where each box is headed while the closets are fresh in your mind. A box that has a destination actually leaves the house.

D DONATE

Clean sheets, towels, blankets and pillows in good shape. Shelters, community groups and some thrift shops take linens. Ask what they accept before you go. Unopened products may be welcome too.

Where it's going: _____

The day I'll drop it off: _____ / _____ / _____

S SELL

Anything worth at least your sell threshold from Week 0. A nice comforter, a set of quality sheets or an unused appliance from the laundry area. Online marketplace, local consignment shop or a garage sale. Log each one in the Sell Tracker in Where It All Went.

Where I'll list it: _____

T TOSS

Worn, stained or torn linens, and expired products. Use worn towels as rags if you want. Check your local household hazardous waste guidelines for cleaners, and never pour products together.

What needs special handling: _____

Keep / Donate / Sell / Toss Count

Each day, write how many items went into each box. Then add up the week.

	KEEP	DONATE	SELL	TOSS
Day 1				
Day 2				
Day 3				
Day 4				
Day 5				
Day 6				
Day 7				
TOTAL				

Estimated value of Sell items: \$ _____ Value of Donate items: \$ _____

Minutes this week: _____ Items out (Donate + Sell + Toss): _____

NOTES

WINS



Garage, Basement, Attic and Storage

This is the biggest volume in the house. The garage, basement, attic and storage unit hold what did not fit anywhere else: tools, holiday decorations, sports gear and boxes nobody has opened since the last move. That is why this week works differently. Big jobs are broken into 15-minute blocks, and you stop when the timer rings.

Pick one area and one shelf, corner or stack per day. Sort into the four boxes as you go. Tools you have never used and duplicates are easy to let go. Holiday decorations get one honest count. A box you have not opened since the last move is a good sign you do not need what is inside, but look before you decide.

Page 3 is a garage sale planning page, and it links to the Sell Tracker and the Donation Log in Where It All Went. One rule for the whole week: paint, chemicals, batteries and broken electronics do not go in the trash or the donate box. Check your local household hazardous waste guidelines first.

WEEK 11 · GARAGE, BASEMENT, ATTIC AND STORAGE

This Week, 15 Minutes a Day

1

Set up the four boxes. Pick your first area. Clear a path to walk in.

15 MIN

☐

2

Tools and workbench. Pull out what you use. Gather the rest.

15 MIN

☐

3

Shelves and hooks. Sort sports gear and yard items.

15 MIN

☐

4

Holiday decorations. Open each bin. Fill in page 4.

15 MIN

☐

5

Boxes from the last move. Open three. Decide on the spot.

15 MIN

☐

6

Paint, chemicals and batteries. Group them. Read page 5.

15 MIN

☐

7

Out the door. Load Toss and Donate. Put the keepers back. Count.

15 MIN

☐

Map Your Garage and Storage Areas

List each place where things pile up. Pick a day for each one, and break the big ones into several 15-minute blocks.

PLACE	DAY	EMPTIED	SORTED	BACK IN PLACE
Garage floor and walls				
Workbench and tool area				
Garage shelves and ceiling racks				
Basement shelves and corners				
Attic or crawl space				
Storage unit or shed				
Yard and sports gear				

The area I have been avoiding: _____

The biggest job I will split into blocks: _____

Something out here I forgot I owned: _____

Plan Your Garage Sale

A garage sale makes sense when you have a lot of things worth at least your sell threshold and a free weekend. If you do not, skip it and use the donate box. Use this page to decide. Log every item you plan to sell in the Sell Tracker in Where It All Went, and log what is left over in the Donation Log.

SALE PLANNING	MY ANSWER	DONE
Sale date and a rain date		
Who is helping		
Items worth selling (count)		
Where I will set up		
Price marked on each item		
What happens to leftovers		

- ☐ I set my garage sale date on the calendar
- ☐ Every item for sale is in the Sell Tracker
- ☐ I have a time and a place for the leftover Donate pickup
- ☐ I checked my local rules for sale permits or signs

Holiday Decorations and Seasonal Gear

Decorations add up because each holiday gets its own bin. Open every one and count. Keep what you will actually put out this year and what has a real story. The rest can go.

HOLIDAY OR SEASON	KEEP	DONATE	SELL	TOSS
Winter holidays				
Spring and Easter				
Summer and patriotic				
Fall and Halloween				
Lights and extension cords				
Wreaths and garland				
Seasonal yard items				
Anything I have not put out in 3 years				

- ☐ Each holiday fits in one bin I can carry
- ☐ Broken or tangled lights are in the Toss box
- ☐ Decorations in good condition are in the Donate box
- ☐ The bins I keep are labeled and easy to reach

Boxes, Tools and Hazardous Items

Start with boxes you have not opened since the last move. Open one, look inside and decide. If you cannot name what is in a box, that tells you something. Next come tools: keep what you use, and let go of what you doubled up on.

ITEM OR BOX	KEEP	DONATE	SELL	TOSS
Unopened boxes from the last move				
Hand tools				
Power tools				
Yard and garden tools				
Sports and outdoor gear				
Broken or rusted tools				
Spare parts and mystery hardware				

- ☐ Paint, chemicals, batteries and broken electronics are set apart from the four boxes
- ☐ I will check my local household hazardous waste guidelines before they leave the house
- ☐ Nothing hazardous is going into the trash or the donate box
- ☐ I asked before getting rid of anything that belongs to someone else

Where It's Going This Week

The garage and attic hold a lot, so plan where each box is going before you fill it. A destination keeps the pile from coming back.

D DONATE

Tools, sports gear and decorations in good shape. Many donation centers take tools and household goods. Ask what they accept and whether they offer pickup for larger items before you go.

Where it's going: _____

The day I'll drop it off: _____ / _____ / _____

S SELL

Anything worth at least your sell threshold from Week 0. Good tools, bikes, sports gear and furniture. Online marketplace, local consignment shop or a garage sale. Log each one in the Sell Tracker in Where It All Went.

Where I'll list it: _____

T TOSS

Broken tools, rusted gear and worn-out items. Check your local household hazardous waste guidelines for paint, chemicals, batteries and broken electronics.

What needs special handling: _____

Keep / Donate / Sell / Toss Count

Each day, write how many items went into each box. Then add up the week.

	KEEP	DONATE	SELL	TOSS
Day 1				
Day 2				
Day 3				
Day 4				
Day 5				
Day 6				
Day 7				
TOTAL				

Estimated value of Sell items: \$ _____ Value of Donate items: \$ _____

Minutes this week: _____ Items out (Donate + Sell + Toss): _____

NOTES

WINS



Sentimental Things, Saved for Last on Purpose

This is the week we saved for last on purpose. Eleven weeks ago, deciding about a hand towel was not easy. Now you have made hundreds of decisions, and you have space in your home and in your head. That is the right time to open the boxes that hold photos, letters, kids' drawings and things that came from someone you love.

The idea this week is simple: keep the memory, and you may not need to keep every object. A photo and a few written lines can hold a story a box of things cannot. Nothing here is a race, and nothing has to go. Keep is always a fine answer. Sell is there if you want it, and you never have to use it.

Work in 15-minute blocks and stop when the timer rings. If a box feels heavy, close it and come back tomorrow. One rule for the week: if something belongs to another family member, ask before you decide.

WEEK 12 · SENTIMENTAL THINGS, SAVED FOR LAST ON PURPOSE

This Week, 15 Minutes a Day

1 Gather and look. Bring the boxes to one table. Do not sort yet. 15 MIN ☐

2 Photos. Pick one stack. Keep the ones you love. 15 MIN ☐

3 Kids' drawings and school work. Choose favorites. Fill in page 4. 15 MIN ☐

4 Letters, cards and papers. Read a few. Sort what you want to keep. 15 MIN ☐

5 Heirlooms and keepsakes. Write each story on page 3. 15 MIN ☐

6 Things that belong to others. Make your list on page 5. 15 MIN ☐

7 Out the door. Put the keepsakes in one place. Count. 15 MIN ☐

Map Your Keepsakes

List where your sentimental things live. Some are in one memory box, and others are scattered. Pick a day for each place and stop when the timer rings.

PLACE	DAY	EMPTIED	SORTED	BACK IN PLACE
Photo boxes and albums				
Kids' art and school folders				
Letters, cards and notes				
Gifts and heirlooms				
Shelf or closet of keepsakes				
Attic, basement or storage boxes				
Phone and computer photos				

The box I have been putting off: _____

The thing I would save first: _____

One item I am ready to decide about today: _____

Keep the Memory, Not Every Object

For an item you are unsure about, take one photo of it and write its story below. You can write a few lines or a single line. Then decide whether the object, the photo or both stay. Keep is always allowed.

ITEM	ITS STORY IN ONE LINE	PHOTO	KEEP

- ☐ I took a photo before I decided anything
- ☐ I wrote who it belonged to, or where it came from
- ☐ I kept the photo and the story in one place

Photos, Kids’ Art, Letters and Heirlooms

Choose favorites, not everything. Many people keep one box for each person in the family and let the rest be photographed. Decide what fits your life.

ITEM OR GROUP	KEEP	DONATE	SELL	TOSS
Printed photos				
Kids’ drawings and crafts				
School work and report cards				
Letters and cards				
Family heirlooms				
Gifts I never liked				
Souvenirs and travel items				
Anything I kept out of duty				

- ☐ Each person’s best pieces are in one labeled box
- ☐ Photos of the rest are saved in one folder, with a backup
- ☐ Keepsakes I am unsure about stay in Keep for now, and I will review them at my 15-minute reset in Keep It Clear
- ☐ Duplicate photos and cards I do not need are in Toss

When It Belongs to Someone Else



Some things in your home are not yours to decide. They may belong to a partner, a grown child or a relative who asked you to hold them. Ask first, and write down the answer.

ITEM	WHOSE IS IT?	WHAT DID THEY SAY?	DATE ASKED

Offer things back in a kind way: “I am making space at home. Would you like this, or shall I hold it until a date we pick?” Put a date on it, and tell them what happens after that.

The conversation I want to have: _____

The date we agreed on: _____

That is the last room. The section called Where It All Went is where you log what you sold and what you donated. In the section called Keep It Clear, you will do a short 15-minute reset each month, so the work you did stays done.

Where It's Going This Week

Sentimental things do not have to leave the house. Make a plan only for what you choose to send on, and keep the rest in one labeled place.

D DONATE

Things others can use and enjoy, such as books, games and household goods that held meaning for you but not for your home now. A thrift store or charity will often take them. For donated items, log them in the Donation Log in Where It All Went.

Where it's going: _____

The day I'll drop it off: _____ / _____ / _____

S SELL

Only if you want to. Some heirlooms and collectibles have value, but keeping them is also fine. If you do sell, log each one in the Sell Tracker in Where It All Went.

Where I'll list it: _____

T TOSS

Damaged items, duplicate papers and things you kept out of duty. Shred papers with personal information and recycle where you can.

What needs special handling: _____

Keep / Donate / Sell / Toss Count

Each day, write how many items went into each box. Then add up the week.

	KEEP	DONATE	SELL	TOSS
Day 1				
Day 2				
Day 3				
Day 4				
Day 5				
Day 6				
Day 7				
TOTAL				

Estimated value of Sell items: \$ _____ Value of Donate items: \$ _____

Minutes this week: _____ Items out (Donate + Sell + Toss): _____

NOTES

WINS

Selling and Donating

By now you have sorted a whole house into four boxes. This part is where you write down what happened to the Sell and Donate boxes. It takes a few minutes each time, and it pays off in three ways.

- **You see the result.** A running total of money earned and value donated is a plain record of the work you did.
- **You learn what is worth the effort.** Listing takes time. An asking price next to a sold price shows you which items were worth it.
- **You have paperwork when you need it.** If you itemize your donations on your taxes, a written log and your receipts make that much easier.

Every week from Week 1 to Week 12 pointed you here. Anything worth at least your sell threshold from Week 0 goes in the Sell Tracker. Everything that went to a charity goes in the Donation Log. Leftovers from a garage sale move from the Sell Tracker to the Donation Log.

Before you start this section

- ☐ I know my sell threshold from Week 0
- ☐ I have a folder or envelope for donation receipts
- ☐ I keep this book near the boxes, with a pencil
- ☐ I will log items when they leave the house, not weeks later

My sell threshold: \$ _____

The day I will sit down to log the Sell box: _____

Where I keep my donation receipts: _____

Where to Sell, Where to Donate

Match the item to the kind of place that handles it well. These are channel types, not recommendations. What is available depends on where you live, so call or check first.

ITEM TYPE	WHERE IT CAN SELL	WHERE IT CAN GO
Clothes	Local consignment shop. Online marketplace or resale app. Garage sale.	Thrift store. Charity shop. Shelter or clothing closet. Clean, wearable items only.
Furniture	Local online listing or community group, buyer picks up. Consignment store. Garage sale.	Charity that takes furniture. Some will pick up. Ask about size and condition rules first.
Electronics	Online marketplace. Local listing. Trade-in program from a manufacturer or store.	Charities that take working items. Electronics recycling for anything broken or old.
Books	Used bookstore. Online marketplace. Garage sale.	Public library (ask about donation rules). Schools, charity shops, little free libraries.
Building materials	Local online listing. Garage sale, for tools and small lots.	Nonprofit reuse store for building materials. Some take donations from homeowners.

Good to know. Call before you load the car, because donation sites can turn items away. Paint, chemicals, batteries and broken electronics may need special handling, so check your local household hazardous waste guidelines. Fees and rules vary. A well-known online marketplace or national thrift chain is an example of a channel type, not a pick.

Where I will sell first: _____

Where I will donate first: _____

Receipts and Form 8283

This page is general information from the IRS, not tax advice. Rules change, and your situation is your own.

- **Keep a receipt for every donation.** Write the date, the organization and a description of what you gave. Drop-off boxes often give no receipt, so make your own note at the time.
- **\$250 or more.** For a contribution of \$250 or more, the IRS requires a written acknowledgment from the charity.
- **Good used condition.** Donated clothing and household items generally need to be in good used condition or better to be deductible.
- **Fair market value.** That means what a buyer would pay for the item in its current condition. The IRS explains how to figure it in Publication 561, Determining the Value of Donated Property.
- **More than \$500 in noncash gifts.** If your deduction for all noncash contributions is more than \$500, you generally file Form 8283 with your return. Items worth more than \$5,000 have extra rules.

Look up the current details at [irs.gov](https://www.irs.gov): Form 8283 and its instructions, Publication 526 (Charitable Contributions) and Publication 561. Check with a tax professional before you file.

My receipts checklist

- ☐ I have a receipt or written note for every donation in the Donation Log
- ☐ I wrote a description and date on each one
- ☐ I kept the acknowledgment for any gift of \$250 or more
- ☐ I added up my noncash donations and compared the total to \$500
- ☐ I talked to a tax professional if I am not sure

Total noncash donations so far: \$ _____

Questions for my tax professional: _____

Sell Tracker

Log each item the day you list it. Come back to fill in the sold price and the date. Add the sold prices at the bottom of the page, then carry the running total forward.

ITEM	WHERE LISTED	ASKING PRICE	SOLD PRICE	DATE SOLD

Total sold on this page: \$ _____ Running total: \$ _____

Sell Tracker, page 2 of 5

[illegible]

Total sold on this page: \$ _____ **Running total: \$ _____**

Sell Tracker, page 3 of 5

[illegible]

Total sold on this page: \$ _____ **Running total: \$ _____**

[illegible]

Total sold on this page: \$ _____ **Running total: \$ _____**

Sell Tracker, page 5 of 5

[illegible]

Total sold on this page: \$ _____ **Running total: \$ _____**

[illegible]

WHERE IT ALL WENT

Donation Log, page 2 of 5

ITEM	CONDITION	FAIR MARKET VALUE	ORGANIZATION	RECEIPT KEPT

Value on this page: \$ _____ Running total: \$ _____

Donation Log, page 3 of 5

ITEM	CONDITION	FAIR MARKET VALUE	ORGANIZATION	RECEIPT KEPT

Value on this page: \$ _____ Running total: \$ _____

Donation Log, page 4 of 5

ITEM	CONDITION	FAIR MARKET VALUE	ORGANIZATION	RECEIPT KEPT

Value on this page: \$ _____ Running total: \$ _____

Donation Log, page 5 of 5

ITEM	CONDITION	FAIR MARKET VALUE	ORGANIZATION	RECEIPT KEPT

Value on this page: \$ _____ Running total: \$ _____

Selling and Donating Totals

Add the page totals from the Sell Tracker and the Donation Log. Carry these numbers to the Conclusion.

SELL TRACKER	TOTAL SOLD
Page 1	
Page 2	
Page 3	
Page 4	
Page 5	

All sold: \$ _____ **Items sold:** _____

DONATION LOG	VALUE DONATED
Page 1	
Page 2	
Page 3	
Page 4	
Page 5	

All donated: \$ _____ **Items donated:** _____

What sold better than I expected: _____

Who received my donations: _____

Keep It Clear

You did the hard part. Every room has been sorted, and the boxes have left the house. Now comes the part that keeps it that way.

Houses slide back slowly. A few bags land by the door, a drawer fills up, a counter collects mail. None of it feels like much on the day, and it adds up. This section gives you three small habits to stop that.

- **The monthly 15-minute reset.** One 15-minute block per room, once a month, tracked on the next two pages.
- **A second look at “Keep for now.”** Anything you were unsure about in Weeks 1 to 12 gets a fresh decision at a reset.
- **One in, one out.** When something new comes into the house, something of the same kind goes out.

You do not need a new system. You already know how to make a decision in 15 minutes. This part only asks you to keep doing it, a little at a time.

Before you start this section

- ☐ All 12 weeks are done, or I have decided which ones to skip
- ☐ I know which day of the month works for my reset
- ☐ I have a pencil and a timer
- ☐ The Keep / Donate / Sell / Toss boxes are still where I left them, or I know where they are going

Today's date: _____ / _____ / _____

The room I will reset first: _____

The day of the month I will reset: _____

Why I want to keep my house clear: _____

Monthly 15-Minute Reset Tracker

Once a month, set a timer for 15 minutes in one room. Put back what drifted, move anything new into Keep, Donate, Sell or Toss, and check the box. Months are undated, so start at Month 1 whenever you finish this book.

ROOM	MONTH 1	MONTH 2	MONTH 3	MONTH 4	MONTH 5	MONTH 6
Bathroom	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Entryway and coat closet	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Kitchen part one: counters, pantry, fridge	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Kitchen part two: cabinets, gadgets, containers	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Living room	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Bedroom	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Closet	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Kids' rooms and toys (or hobby room)	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Home office and paper pile	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Linen closet, laundry, cleaning supplies	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Garage, basement, attic, storage	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Sentimental things	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

My reset day each month: _____

Monthly 15-Minute Reset Tracker, continued

ROOM	MONTH 7	MONTH 8	MONTH 9	MONTH 10	MONTH 11	MONTH 12
Bathroom	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Entryway and coat closet	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Kitchen part one: counters, pantry, fridge	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Kitchen part two: cabinets, gadgets, containers	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Living room	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Bedroom	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Closet	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Kids' rooms and toys (or hobby room)	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Home office and paper pile	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Linen closet, laundry, cleaning supplies	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Garage, basement, attic, storage	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Sentimental things	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

Resets done in all 12 months: _____ / 144

Revisit “Keep for now”

Some things were not a clear yes or no. The rule was simple: when you truly could not decide, it stayed in Keep for now, and you would look again at a 15-minute reset. This is that page.

Ask the same question you asked in Week 0: **If this were gone tomorrow, would I go out and buy it again?** If yes, it stays in Keep and goes back to its place. If no, it goes to Donate, Sell or Toss, using your sell threshold.

ITEM I KEPT FOR NOW	ROOM	KEEP	DONATE	SELL	TOSS

- ☐ I asked the question for every item on this list
- ☐ Anything that changed to Donate, Sell or Toss went into the right box
- ☐ Sell items were added to the Sell Tracker, Donate items to the Donation Log

Next time I will look at this page again: _____ / _____ / _____

One In, One Out

The rule is short. When something new comes into the house, something of the same kind goes out. A new pair of shoes means one old pair leaves. A new mug means one mug goes. A new book means one book goes.

Out means it leaves the house. It goes into Donate, Sell or Toss. It does not go into a bag in the closet.

- **Same kind.** Swap like for like, so a jacket replaces a jacket.
- **Same week.** Do it within a week, before the new item settles in.
- **Gifts count.** You can say thank you and still let something else go.
- **Small things are your call.** Decide ahead of time whether pens and greeting cards count, and stick to it.

One In, One Out Log

WHAT CAME IN	WHAT WENT OUT	WHERE IT WENT	DONE

What Comes Next

Your house is clear, and you have a way to keep it that way. The next step is to keep it clean. That is where the *House Cleaning Checklist Planner* picks up.

Decluttering and cleaning work together. Clear surfaces are much quicker to wipe. Because you made a place for what you kept, the *House Cleaning Checklist Planner* routine can move room by room in 15-minute blocks, without stopping to move piles.

Use this table to plan where the routine starts. Pick a day and a time for each room, and check it off once the room is in your routine.

ROOM	DAY	TIME	SET
Bathroom			☐
Entryway and coat closet			☐
Kitchen part one: counters, pantry, fridge			☐
Kitchen part two: cabinets, gadgets, containers			☐
Living room			☐
Bedroom			☐
Closet			☐
Kids' rooms and toys (or hobby room)			☐
Home office and paper pile			☐
Linen closet, laundry, cleaning supplies			☐
Garage, basement, attic, storage			☐
Sentimental things			☐

Before I pick up the routine

- ☐ My surfaces are clear and everything has a place
- ☐ My cleaning supplies are gathered from Week 10
- ☐ I picked a day for my monthly 15-minute reset
- ☐ I know my one in, one out rule

The day I will start my cleaning routine: _____ / _____ / _____

My reset day each month: _____

One room I want to keep clear above all: _____

Your Before and After

You started with a walk through your home and a pencil. Now you can do the same walk again. Go room by room, don't pick anything up, and give each space the same 1 to 5 rating you used in Week 0. Trust your first reaction, as you did then.

Copy your Week 0 ratings from "Rate Your Rooms" into the first column, then write today's number in the second. Take the after photo from the same spot in the doorway as the before photo, and check the box. Some rooms moved a lot, some a little. Both count.

- ① **Calm.** Easy to use, and everything has a place.
- ③ **Crowded.** You can use it, but it takes effort to find or put away things.
- ⑤ **Stuck.** You avoid the room, or it can't be used the way it was meant to be.

WEEK	ROOM	WEEK 0 RATING	RATING NOW	AFTER PHOTO
Week 1	Bathroom			☐
Week 2	Entryway and coat closet			☐
Week 3	Kitchen, part one: counters, pantry, fridge			☐
Week 4	Kitchen, part two: cabinets, gadgets, containers			☐
Week 5	Living room			☐
Week 6	Bedroom			☐
Week 7	Closet			☐
Week 8	Kids' rooms and toys (or hobby room)			☐
Week 9	Home office and paper pile			☐
Week 10	Linen closet, laundry, cleaning supplies			☐
Week 11	Garage, basement, attic, storage			☐
Week 12	Sentimental things			☐

Total before: _____ / 60 **Total now:** _____ / 60 **Change:** _____

Your Weekly Counts

Copy the totals from the “Keep / Donate / Sell / Toss Count” page at the end of each week. Then add up each column. Items out are the items that left the house: Donate, Sell and Toss.

	KEEP	DONATE	SELL	TOSS	ITEMS OUT
Week 1					
Week 2					
Week 3					
Week 4					
Week 5					
Week 6					
Week 7					
Week 8					
Week 9					
Week 10					
Week 11					
Week 12					
Total					

Items out, all 12 weeks (Donate + Sell + Toss): _____

Items kept, all 12 weeks: _____

The week with the biggest number: _____

Your Scoreboard

Four numbers sum up the 12 weeks. Take the first three from your counts and from “Selling and Donating Totals”, and work out the fourth below.

Items out Donate + Sell + Toss, from the weekly counts	
Money earned “All sold” from Selling and Donating Totals	\$
Value donated “All donated” from Selling and Donating Totals	\$
Hours invested Worked out below	

Work Out Your Hours

Most days you used a single 15-minute block. Count the days you did the work, including the extra blocks, and multiply.

_____ days × 15 minutes = _____ minutes

_____ minutes ÷ 60 = _____ hours

The number that surprised me: _____

What I sold that I’m glad I sold: _____

The donation I’m proudest of: _____

Who benefited most from it: _____

What You Did

You made a few hundred small decisions, 15 minutes at a time. Nobody handed you a finished room. You built these results one drawer and one shelf at a time.

The house will not stay this way on its own, and that is fine. Use the monthly 15-minute reset and one in, one out from Keep It Clear. They take little time, and they keep the work from piling up again.

If you want to keep the house clean now that it's clear, the *House Cleaning Checklist Planner* builds a routine in the same 15-minute blocks. More books from Emily P. Harper are on the way, and the Final Words page at the back tells you where to find them.

Before I close this book

- ☐ I rated all 12 rooms again and took the after photos
- ☐ I filled in my scoreboard
- ☐ My Donate and Sell boxes have left the house
- ☐ My monthly reset day is on my calendar

NOTES

WINS

Your Printable Declutter Kit

Some pages work better on a wall than inside a book. The Printable Declutter Kit is a free PDF with the sheets that work best taped up where you can see them while you work, so you can print them as often as you need.

What's in the kit:

- **A Keep / Donate / Sell / Toss flowchart.** The same tie-breaker from Week 0, laid out as a one-page chart you can stick inside a closet door and check while your hands are full.
- **Room checklists to print again.** One per room, so you have a clean copy for each monthly 15-minute reset in Keep It Clear instead of writing over last month's marks.
- **A 12-week tracker for the fridge door.** Check off each week as you finish it. Everyone in the house can see how far you've come, and nobody has to open the book to find out.

To get the kit, scan the code below with your phone's camera. You'll be asked for an email address to get the download.



If other people in the house are joining in, print a flowchart for each of them, which saves a lot of “which box does this go in?” questions while you work.

Final Words

Twelve weeks ago you walked through your home with a pencil and gave every room a score. If you are reading this page, you have gone through that list one room at a time, and the before-and-after page in the Conclusion has the numbers to show for it. Thank you for letting this book keep you company while you did the work.

If the book helped, I'd be grateful for a short review on Amazon. Tell other readers what worked for you and what didn't. An honest review, even a sentence or two, helps the next person decide whether a slow, 15-minute plan is the right fit for their home, and it doesn't have to be glowing to be useful.

If something in these pages was confusing, or you have an idea for making the next edition better, I'd like to hear it. You can write to me at hello@readpublishingco.com. Every message is read by a person, though a reply can take a few days.

Once the clutter is out, the *House Cleaning Checklist Planner* picks up where *Keep It Clear* leaves off, with weekly and monthly checklists and cleaning routines for every room. It comes in a black-and-white edition and a full-color one. More books are on the way, and you can find the planner and everything else I publish at www.readpublishingco.com/#emily.

With thanks,

Emily P. Harper